

VEER

Paperwork and Plain English

The letter, the bill, the lease, the form — translated into words you can act on.

You are here

By the end of this guide you'll be able to:

Know exactly what this can and can't do for you — that's Lesson 1, before anything else.

Read a letter that was written to be difficult.

Understand a bill line by line, including the lines nobody explains.

Work out what a contract obliges you to do without pretending that's legal advice.

Fill in a form without the dread, and know what you need before you start.

Compare two options and see what's missing from both.

Write back in a way that gets a person to act.

Recognise when to stop and pay someone who knows.

01

What this will and won't do

This lesson comes first on purpose. Everything after it depends on the line being clear.

What this does well. It translates. A letter full of clauses becomes four sentences. A bill becomes a list you understand. A form becomes steps. A contract becomes "here's what you've agreed to do, and here's what looks unusual." It's excellent at this, and it's genuinely useful.

What it does not do. It does not know your circumstances, your jurisdiction, your history with the company, or the law where you live. It does not know whether a price is fair, whether a clause is enforceable, or whether you have a case.

Put plainly:

Understanding what a document says. **Yes.**

Preparing the questions worth asking about it. **Yes.**

Drafting a reply for you to check and send. **Yes.**

Advising you on what to do about it. **No.**

Telling you whether something is legal, fair, or worth accepting. **No.**

THE ONE-SENTENCE VERSION

Use it to walk into the conversation understanding your own paperwork. Take the decision to a person who is qualified and who can see your actual situation.

Try this now. Nothing yet. Read that box again — it's the reason the rest of the book is safe to use.

02

A letter designed to be confusing

Some letters are hard because the subject is complex. Others are hard because clarity wasn't the goal — an unclear letter produces fewer replies, and fewer replies is sometimes the point.

You can't tell which you're holding, and it doesn't matter. The move is the same.

THE OPENING ASK

I'll paste in a letter. Tell me what it's actually about, whether it's asking me to do anything, whether there's a deadline, and whether anything in it should concern me.

Four questions, not one. "What does this mean" gets you a summary. These get you a decision.

Remove your details first. Account numbers, reference numbers, your address, anyone's name. The letter works fine without them, and *Is This Safe?* covers why this matters.

Ask what's missing. The most useful question about an evasive letter is *what would you expect a letter like this to say that this one doesn't?* Gaps are often the whole story.

Ask what happens if you do nothing. Sometimes the honest answer is "nothing," and that changes how urgently you need to deal with it.

THE TONE QUESTION

Ask *is this a standard letter or has something escalated?* A reader who deals with these all day can tell. You can't, and it changes your response.

Try this now. Find the letter you've been avoiding. Redact it. Ask the four questions.

03

A bill, line by line

Bills are designed by people who understand them, for systems that process them, and are read by you.

Ask for the line-by-line, not the summary.

THE BILL ASK

I'll paste in an energy bill with the account number removed.
Explain what each line means, what I'm actually being charged for, and whether anything looks unusual for a household of two in a small flat.

Adding your circumstances lets it say *that seems high for what you've described*, which is the sentence you wanted.

When it's higher than last time, don't ask why. It can't see last time. Describe both.

THE COMPARISON

Last quarter I paid £180 and this quarter it's £310. Nothing has changed about the house. Ask me questions about my usage and the bill, then tell me what's worth checking.

Then ask what to check yourself. Meter readings, an estimated bill, a tariff that ended, a standing charge that changed. It doesn't know which happened — it knows what to look for.

IT CANNOT TELL YOU WHETHER YOU'VE BEEN OVERCHARGED

It can tell you what a line means and what would be worth querying. Whether the figure is right is between you and the company, and the meter.

Try this now. Take any bill and ask what each line means. Most people have never actually known.

04

A lease, a warranty, a contract

The most valuable use in this book, and the one that needs the firmest hand.

What you're doing is comprehension, not legal advice. The distinction is real. *What does clause 14 oblige me to do* is comprehension. *Is clause 14 enforceable* is law, and this isn't the place for it.

THE CONTRACT ASK

I'll paste in a tenancy agreement. Explain in plain English what I'd be agreeing to do, what the landlord is agreeing to do, and flag anything that reads as unusual compared with a standard agreement of this kind.

"Flag anything unusual" is the phrase that earns the price of this book. You don't know what's standard. It has read enough of these to notice when something isn't — and then you know what to ask about.

Ask what isn't there. *What would you normally expect in an agreement like this that's missing here?*

Ask what it would cost you. *Which of these clauses could cost me money, and in what circumstances?*

THEN STOP, AND TAKE IT TO A PERSON

Anything you're about to sign that involves your home, your job, significant money, or a commitment longer than a year is worth a professional's eye. Use this to arrive at that conversation already understanding the document and knowing your questions. That is a genuinely valuable place to arrive — and it is not the same as advice.

Try this now. Take a contract you've already signed. See what it actually says.

05

Filling in a form without dread

Forms are unpleasant less because they're hard than because they're uncertain. You don't know what a section wants, whether you have the right information, or what happens if you get it wrong. So it sits on the table for three weeks.

Ask what you need before you start. Half the dread is discovering at question 14 that you need a document from 2019.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

I'll paste in the questions from a form. Tell me what information and documents I need to gather before I start, and explain any sections that are worded confusingly.

Ask what people commonly get wrong. Applications get delayed for the same handful of reasons, and it knows what they are.

Ask it to help you word the awkward box. The "explain your circumstances" field is where people freeze. Describe your situation and ask for a clear, factual paragraph.

HONESTY, NOT PRESENTATION

Ask for the wording to be *clear and factual*, not persuasive. A form is not a pitch, and a paragraph that oversells is worse than one that plainly states the position. Never let it write something that isn't true of you.

Try this now. Take the form on your table. Ask only what you need to gather. Do that much today.

06

Comparing two options

Two quotes, two policies, two tariffs, two schools. The information exists but it's in two different shapes, and comparing them is exactly the sort of tedious work people avoid — so they pick the cheaper one and hope.

THE COMPARISON ASK

I'll paste in two insurance quotes. Put them side by side as a table, tell me what's in one and not the other, and list what neither of them covers.

That third clause is the valuable one. The gap between two options is usually smaller than the gap between both of them and what you assumed you were getting.

Ask what would change the answer. *What would make the more expensive one the right choice?* turns a price comparison into a decision you understand.

Ask about the excess, the exclusions, and the renewal. Those three are where the difference usually hides.

IT DOESN'T KNOW WHAT'S RIGHT FOR YOU

It can lay out the differences. Whether the cheaper policy is a false economy depends on your circumstances, your risk, and your finances — and for anything that matters, a broker or adviser who can see all three.

Try this now. Take any two things you're choosing between and ask what neither of them covers.

07

Writing back so a person acts

You've understood the document. Now something has to be sent, and a badly-framed reply lands in a queue and stays there.

Four things get a reply actioned:

A reference and a date, in the first line.

One specific request. Two requests halves your chances.

What you've already done, with dates.

A response date, and a reason for it.

THE REPLY ASK

Write a reply to this letter asking them to reconsider a decision. Keep it factual and polite, put my reference number and the date at the top, and make one clear request rather than several.

Ask who should receive it. *Who would normally handle this, and is there a complaints process I should be using instead?* is a question people never think to ask, and it saves weeks.

Keep a record. Ask it to summarise what you sent and when, and keep that. Correspondence about paperwork has a way of running for months.

READ IT BEFORE YOU SEND IT

Everything in Letters, Emails, and Awkward Messages applies here: cut the first sentence, count the apologies, move the request to the top. A polite letter with the ask buried on line nine gets filed.

Try this now. Draft the reply. Sleep on it. Send it tomorrow.

08

When to stop and call someone

The last lesson, and the most important one in the book.

Stop and pay for advice when any of these is true:

A deadline has legal weight. A court date, a statutory notice, a period for appeal.

Your home is involved. Eviction, repossession, a boundary, a lease extension.

Your job is involved. Dismissal, a settlement agreement, a grievance.

Someone has threatened action, or you're considering it.

The amount would genuinely hurt to lose.

You can't undo it once done.

You've read it three times and still can't tell what it means.

That last one deserves saying plainly. Persistent confusion about a document is not a failure of your intelligence. It's often a signal that the document is genuinely complex, or that something in it is being obscured. Either way it's a reason to get help, not to try harder.

Where help is often free. Citizens' advice services, charities specialising in housing, debt or employment, a union, an ombudsman scheme, or an insurance policy you already hold that includes legal cover. Many people pay for advice they were already entitled to.

THE MOST USEFUL THING THIS BOOK CAN DO FOR YOU

Walk into that appointment with the document understood, the questions written down, and the timeline clear. An hour of professional time spent on your actual question is worth several spent explaining the background. That preparation is the real value here.

Try this now. For the document worrying you most — check the list above. If it's on it, find out who advises on that where you live.

The plain-English pass

Three asks, in this order, on any document. Redact the personal details first.

1 — What is this? *Tell me what this document is, whether it's asking me to do anything, whether there's a deadline, and whether anything in it should concern me.*

2 — What does it say? *Now go through it section by section in plain English. Flag anything that reads as unusual for a document of this kind, and tell me what you'd expect to see that isn't here.*

3 — What now? *What should I ask about this, what should I check myself, and is this something I should be taking to a professional?*

The third ask is the one people skip, and it's the one that stops this being a summary and makes it useful.

When it goes wrong

"It gave me a summary, not an explanation." Ask for it section by section. "Summarise" and "explain each part" are different requests.

"It sounded confident about the law." Treat that as a prompt to check, not an answer. Ask *is this something that varies by jurisdiction or by circumstance?* — it usually is, and saying so out loud recalibrates the whole conversation.

"It said something different when I asked again." A real signal. Inconsistency on a specific point means it's unsure, and that point is exactly what to take to a person.

"It invented a clause." It fills gaps. Paste the document rather than describing it, and ask it to quote the wording it's referring to.

"I don't want to paste this in." Reasonable. Describe it instead — *I've had a letter saying my claim was refused because of a pre-existing condition clause* gets you most of the way with none of the document. See *Is This Safe?*.

"It's telling me what to do." It will if you ask. Reframe: *don't tell me what to do — tell me what this says and what I should ask.* You'll get better material and stay on the right side of the line.

THE PATTERN

Everything in this book is one move: turn "what should I do?" into "what does this say, and what should I ask?" The second question it can answer well. The first belongs to you and to someone qualified.

If you only do one thing

Take one habit and leave the other seven.

Ask what's unusual, not what it says.

You can broadly work out what a document says by reading it slowly twice. What you cannot do — because you've never seen a hundred of them — is know what's *normal*.

Flag anything that reads as unusual for a document of this kind, and tell me what you'd expect to see that isn't here.

That single sentence turns a translation into something genuinely useful: the list of things worth asking about. And the list of things worth asking about is what you take to the person who can actually advise you.

Do this next

About to reply to something? → Letters, Emails, and Awkward Messages — the complaint that gets results, and the reply that gets a person to act.

Cautious about pasting documents in? → Is This Safe? — what it can and can't see, and the four things never to type. Read it before you paste anything with your details on it.

Want your requests to land first time? → Asking Better Questions — the four things that turn a generic answer into a useful one.

Quotes and household admin? → Around the House — reading a quote for what it doesn't cover.

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